Census and Urbanisation Topic 3 — Population Composition and Demographic Characteristics

Current Affairs

Year	Fact	Why it matters
Rolling	Refresh edition-bound figures from latest Census / Survey / State CA desks.	Do not invent interim totals.

UP district extremes also → UP Special Topic 6. This chapter owns the national Census / demography desk.

Teaching cards

2.1 Age Structure, Dependency Ratio, and Workforce Classification

A. The Three Broad Age Cohorts

1. **Young / Child Cohort (0–14 Years)**: - Constitutes approximately **30.8%** of India's population in Census 2011 (declined from 35.3% in 2001). - Biologically and legally dependent; requires social investment in nutrition, immunization, and primary/secondary schooling.
2. **Working-Age Cohort (15–59 Years)**: - Constitutes approximately **60.3%** of India's population in Census 2011 (increased from 57.1% in 2001). - The economically active, tax-paying, and output-generating engine of the economy. Forms the basis of India's **Demographic Dividend**.
3. **Elderly / Senior Citizen Cohort (60+ Years)**: - Constitutes approximately **8.6%** of India's population in Census 2011 (increased from 7.5% in 2001; projected to reach ~15% by 2036). - Economically dependent; requires geriatric healthcare, pensions, and assisted-living social security infrastructure.

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                AGE COMPOSITION OF INDIA'S POPULATION (CENSUS 2011)
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| Child Population (0-14 Yrs): ~30.8%  | Working Age (15-59 Yrs): ~60.3% | 60+:8.6%|
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B. Dependency Ratio Formulations

- **Total Dependency Ratio (TDR)**: ext{TDR} = rac{ ext{Population (0–14)} + ext{Population (60+)}}{ ext{Working-Age Population (15–59)}} imes 100
- India's Total Dependency Ratio fell from **75.2%** in 2001 to **65.2%** in 2011, reflecting the expanding demographic dividend.
- **Young Dependency Ratio (YDR)**: ext{YDR} = rac{ ext{Population (0–14)}}{ ext{Working-Age Population (15–59)}} imes 100

- **Old-Age / Elderly Dependency Ratio (ODR)**: ext{ODR} = rac{ ext{Population (60+)}}{ ext{Working-Age Population (15–59)}} imes 100

C. Workforce & Economic Activity Classification in Census

The Census of India classifies the total population into three broad economic categories based on work duration during the reference year: 1. **Main Workers**: Persons who engaged in any economically productive activity for **183 days (6 months) or more** during the preceding 365 days. 2. **Marginal Workers**: Persons who worked for **less than 183 days (less than 6 months)** during the preceding year (further categorized into those working for 0–3 months and 3–6 months). 3. **Non-Workers**: Persons who did not engage in any economic work during the entire year (students, homemakers, dependents, retired persons, beggars). - **Four Standard Industrial Categories of Workers**: - **Cultivators (CL)**: Persons engaged in farming/cultivating land owned or held from government/private persons (24.6% of total workers). - **Agricultural Labourers (AL)**: Persons who work on another person's land for wages in money or kind without holding ownership/lease rights (30.0% of total workers). - **Household Industry Workers (HHI)**: Workers in manufacturing, processing, servicing, or repairing conducted within the home by household members (3.8%). - **Other Workers (OW)**: All workers engaged in factories, government, commerce, IT, transport, mining, and services (41.6%).

2.2 Literacy Rates & Educational Attainment

A. Effective Literacy Rate Definition

In Indian census terminology, a person aged **7 years and above** who can both read and write with understanding in any language is considered **literate**. A person who can only read but cannot write is classified as illiterate. ext{Effective Literacy Rate (\%)} = rac{ ext{Total Literate Population Aged 7+}}{ ext{Total Population Aged 7+}} imes 100 *(Note: Prior to the 1991 Census, literacy was calculated for the population aged 5 years and above).*

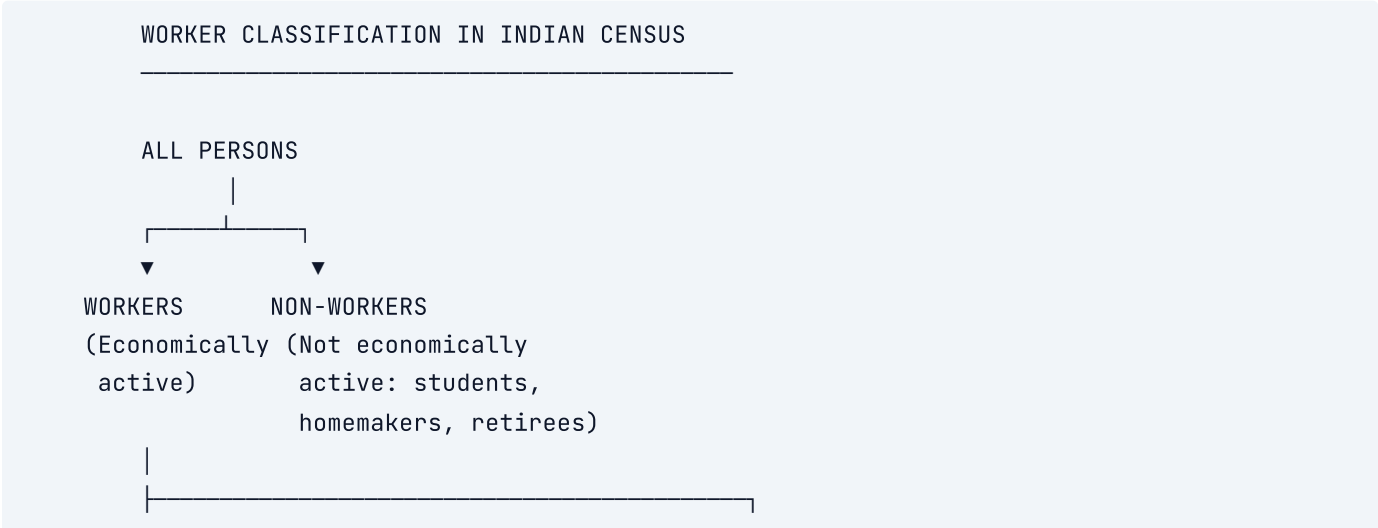
B. Literacy Disparities & Gender Gap

- **National Level (2011)**: Overall: **73.0%**; Male: **80.9%**; Female: **64.6%**; Gender Gap: **16.3%** (declined from 21.6% in 2001).
- **Highest Literacy States**: Kerala (**94.0%**), Mizoram (**91.3%**), Goa (**88.7%**), Tripura (**87.2%**).
- **Lowest Literacy States**: Bihar (**61.8%**), Arunachal Pradesh (**65.4%**), Rajasthan (**66.1%**), Jharkhand (**66.4%**), Andhra Pradesh (**67.0%**), Uttar Pradesh (**67.7%**).
- **Gender Gap Extremes**:
- **Widest Gender Gap**: **Rajasthan (27.1%)** (Male: 79.2%, Female: 52.1%), followed by Jharkhand (21.4%) and Dadra & Nagar Haveli (20.9%).
- **Narrowest Gender Gap**: **Meghalaya (3.1%)** (Male: 76.0%, Female: 72.9%), followed by Kerala (4.0%) and Mizoram (4.0%).

Bilingual Terminology — Population Composition (जनसंख्या संरचना)

English Term	हिंदी पारिभाषिक शब्द	Key Anchor
Age-Sex Pyramid	आयु-लिंग पिरामिड	Graphical representation of population age-sex structure
Working Age Population	कार्यशील आयु जनसंख्या	15–64 years; basis of demographic dividend
Dependency Ratio	निर्भरता अनुपात	Young (0–14) + Old (65+) / Working age (15–64)
Main Workers	मुख्य श्रमिक	Worked ≥ 183 days in reference year
Marginal Workers	सीमांत श्रमिक	Worked < 183 days in reference year
Non-Workers	अश्रमिक	Did not work at all during reference year
Cultivators	कृषक	Engaged in agricultural cultivation on own/leased land
Agricultural Labourers	कृषि श्रमिक	Work on others' land for wages/share of crop
Household Industry Workers	गृह उद्योग श्रमिक	Work in cottage industries within or adjacent to household
Other Workers	अन्य श्रमिक	All workers not in above three categories
Religious Minority	धार्मिक अल्पसंख्यक	Non-majority religious communities; 6 notified minorities in India
Scheduled Caste (अनुसूचित जाति)	SC	Article 341 — Presidential notification
Scheduled Tribe (अनुसूचित जनजाति)	ST	Article 342 — Presidential notification
Worker Participation Rate	श्रमिक सहभागिता दर	Percentage of workers in total population

Extended Theory — Worker Classification System (Census 2011)



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MAIN WORKERS                              MARGINAL WORKERS
(≥ 183 days / year)                       (< 183 days / year)
        |
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        |        4 CATEGORIES      |
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1. CULTIVATORS (कृषक) — own/leased land
2. AGRICULTURAL LABOURERS (कृषि श्रमिक) — wage on others' land
3. HOUSEHOLD INDUSTRY (गृह उद्योग) — cottage industry
4. OTHER WORKERS (अन्य श्रमिक) — all remaining categories
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Religious Composition of India — Census 2011

Religion	Population (%)	Key Concentration States
Hinduism	**79.8%**	Himachal Pradesh (95.2%), Odisha, Chhattisgarh
Islam	**14.2%**	J&K, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, UP
Christianity	**2.3%**	Nagaland (87.9%), Mizoram (87.2%), Meghalaya (74.6%)
Sikhism	**1.7%**	Punjab (57.7%)
Buddhism	**0.7%**	Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Ladakh
Jainism	**0.4%**	Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra
Other / Not Stated	**0.9%**	Various

Key Exam Traps on Religious Demography: - **Highest Muslim % State**: Jammu & Kashmir (68.3% prior to bifurcation; Lakshadweep 96.2% among UTs) - **Highest Christian % State**: Nagaland (87.9%), followed by Mizoram (87.2%) - **Highest Sikh % State**: Punjab (57.7%) — only State with Sikh majority - **Highest Buddhist % State**: Sikkim (27.4%); Arunachal Pradesh also significant

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One-Liner Revision — Population Composition

#	Fast Fact
1	Workers classified into **4 types**: Cultivators, Agricultural Labourers, Household Industry, Other
2	Main workers = ≥ **183 days** per year
3	Marginal workers = < **183 days** per year
4	Highest SC % State = **Punjab (31.9%)**
5	Highest SC absolute = **Uttar Pradesh (4.14 Crore, 20.70%)**
6	Highest ST % = **Lakshadweep (94.8%)** — UT; **Mizoram (94.4%)** — State

#	Fast Fact
7	Highest ST absolute = **Madhya Pradesh (1.53 Crore)**
8	Zero SC States = **Nagaland, Mizoram, Meghalaya, Lakshadweep, A&N**
9	Zero ST States = **Punjab, Haryana, Delhi, Chandigarh, Puducherry**
10	India's Worker Participation Rate (WPR) 2011 ≈ **39.79%**
11	India's male WPR > female WPR (reflect social norms)
12	Highest Muslim % UT = **Lakshadweep (96.2%)**
13	Highest Sikh % State = **Punjab (57.7%)**
14	Highest Christian % State = **Nagaland (87.9%)**
15	SC listed under **Article 341**; ST under **Article 342**